

excelling. That's where Apollo comes in. Apollo has had a similar journey. In 1976, the company was bankrupt, and today we are number one in India. That has come from resilience, excellence, continuous effort, discovering ourselves, and investing in technology to become leaders.

Sachin [Tendulkar] comes in as the god of cricket, a mentor figure guiding these kids. In the same way, my father, the chairman, has been a mentor to our 20,000 employees. Even today, as mobility evolves, he continues to guide us. That's the correlation between Sachin and the chairman.

You mentioned Sachin. What also stood out was the choice of players — Virat Kohli, Rohit Sharma, and Shubman Gill. Given that Virat and Rohit have retired from T20s and Gill isn't part of the current World Cup setup, what was the thinking behind this selection?

You said it yourself. They are currently the top players.

Apollo is also a top company. So why would I go for second-best when I have access to the best?

These players have strong journeys. A lot of research has gone into the casting. Virat's younger version looks identical, but the same effort has gone into the others too, including parents and costumes.

Their journeys are all different but equally difficult. Take Rohit, for instance. He grew up in a *chawl* in Mumbai, and his journey from there to here is significant.

Is there a possibility of doing something similar with the women's team, given their recent success?

We are looking into it. I'm very excited because, since Apollo tied up on the jersey, we've already had two World Cups — one with the women's team and one at the Under-19 level.

We have now added a T20 title as well. So yes, the women's team is very much on my mind. Right now, we are just on the jersey, but discussions are ongoing internally.

Cricket guarantees visibility in India. But as a brand, how do you ensure that this translates into actual value and not just visibility?

We have done this with ROI in mind. ₹580 crore is not a small investment. Since tying up on the jersey in September, we have seen sales increase, better distribution, new dealers, and higher throughput at dealer counters.

This is especially visible in car tyres, scooter tyres, and tractor tyres. The biggest advantage is rural reach. Cricket allows us to reach all of India instantly. People in villages are watching on phones and TVs. That awareness is driving growth in rural markets.

Apollo has also invested in football, both in India and Europe. Given the uncertainty around Indian football, do you still see it as a viable space?

Football is growing in India. India needs to become a sporting nation. Investment should go into multiple sports, not just cricket. The government needs to replicate cricket's success across other sports.

We are seeing progress. With increased focus, India is winning more medals at the Asian Games and Olympics. A strong public-private partnership can help identify and nurture talent.

Football is becoming popular, especially with global influences like Lionel Messi. European clubs are also looking at India for academies and talent. There is recognition that India has potential.

Have your European partnerships offered insights into how similar models could work in India?

The key issue in India is infrastructure. In cricket, we have built world-class stadiums. Ahmedabad, for example, is phenomenal. Compared to Old Trafford, it stands out.

So we have the capability. The question is why we are not doing this across all sports. We were dominant in hockey once but have slipped.

If we invest in infrastructure and

training across sports, India can succeed. We have proven ourselves in business, technology, and science. The issue is focus.

Right now, 90 per cent of attention goes to cricket. If leadership sets a clear target, like 100 Olympic medals, I'm confident it can happen.

Infrastructure and funding would follow. Without direction, efforts get fragmented.

This also discourages private investment. For example, we partnered with Mahesh Bhupathi to produce a Grand Slam singles champion.

But due to interference from governing bodies, we had to withdraw. If such issues are resolved, any sport can grow. Also, cricket is overcrowded. Talent needs to move into other sports.

Finally, which sports vertical does Apollo see itself investing in over the next five years?

We were not in cricket earlier. My vision was to enter only when we became a brand leader. I didn't want smaller branding opportunities.

When the right opportunity came, we committed — and this is a long-term commitment.

When I spoke to the BCCI, I made it clear this is not a short-term deal. I believe in long-term partnerships. We've been with Manchester United for 12 years.

Even during their downturn, we stayed committed. Similarly, we will continue investing in cricket in India. India accounts for 65 per cent of our business. Cricket is also growing globally, so focusing on it will help build the brand.

With cricket set to feature in the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, will popularity drive future investment decisions? And would you consider other sports?

Yes, popularity will be a key factor. For Apollo, cricket will remain the focus. However, with our Vredestein brand in Europe, we invest in football, skiing, and marathons. In India, we are involved in golf as well.